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The Fool and His Money

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The Fool and His Money

The house of the righteous contains great treasure, but the income of the wicked brings them trouble. (Proverbs 15:6)

A good man leaves an inheritance to his children's children, but the sinner's wealth is laid up for the righteous. (Proverbs 13:22)

In the house of the wise are scores of choice food and oil, but a foolish man devours all he has. (Proverbs 21:20)

When someone heard the maxim, "A fool and his money are soon parted," he responded, "How did the fool get any money in the first place?" Good question. If there is any truism that is economically sound, it is that "wisdom is a more significant factor in wealth acquisition than stupidity."

It seems clear that King Solomon, one of history's richest men, understood that sin in one's life mitigates against life success—including financial success. The common experience among celebrities, whether they be pro athletes or media stars, is to receive vast wealth and then lose it to a lifestyle of sin and folly.

Principle: The single most significant factor in wealth acquisition is righteous character. Sin and stupidity are thieves.

I once interviewed the author of a book based on research into lottery and sweepstakes winners. The conclusion to the research was clear. Most winners wished they had never won; and only a handful had much, if anything, of the windfall left even a few years after. This pattern of wasted wealth has led some to speculate that if the riches of the wealthy were distributed evenly among the world's people, within ten years 90 percent of the money would be back in the hands of the original owners. One thing is sure, the wise and righteous people would have an odds-on advantage in recovering lost wealth and even passing it along as an inheritance. Proverbs even declares that what sinners collect is destined for ultimate ownership by the righteous!

Principle: Both acquiring and retaining significant wealth are predicated on right living. Spending on self and sinful pleasures is like signing over resources to the godly; they'll end up with them eventually anyway.

The method and motivation deployed in acquiring wealth are often missed factors in the pursuit of prosperity. Proverbs declares that ill-gotten gain will vanish and bring with it heaps of trouble (13:11 with 15:6).

Principle: Wealth secured through righteous motivation and God-honoring methods has built-in loss insurance. Even if lost, it will be restored.

Someone has said, “Money can’t buy happiness. It just helps pay for your misery.” If prosperity does not come as God’s reward for righteous living, it will not only fail to pay for your misery, but it will come packaged with more of it.

[from “*Wisdom for the Trenches*” by Dr. Larry W. Poland]